Math graduate program guidelines on ethics of using AI for research

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Rapid progress of LLMs in Math research creates incredible opportunities but also unprecedented challenges for the community. Therefore, it is imperative that those of us who use AI do so in an ethical and responsible way, avoiding harm both to others and to their own mathematical education and research.

Since the situation is constantly evolving, the Math Department does not currently have, and does not expect to have in the future, any policy on whether and how students use AI for their research. Instead, each student should regularly discuss such usage with their thesis advisor (all of them if the student has multiple advisors; students who do not yet have a thesis advisor should consult the DGS).

The Math Department institutes the following policies and recommendations related to the ethics of AI usage.

1) In the work submitted for evaluation in the degree program (including the prospectus or the thesis), students have to acknowledge their individual use of AI, assuming this use influences the intellectual content. The list of items to be acknowledged is provided in the Appendix. Significant omissions in this acknowledgement may be treated as academic misconduct. If a part of the thesis is based on a joint work, students are encouraged to solicit descriptions of AI use by coauthors and include this in the acknowledgement. Students also need to carefully review all AI contributions themselves, verify, and take responsibility for their correctness. Students can reference the Personal Conduct and Academic Integrity Standards < Yale University, which is consistent with the present guidelines, when submitting any work for evaluation in their degree program.
2) Students are strongly encouraged to follow the guidelines in 1) in all papers that they make public, e.g., on arXiv. Significant omissions may tarnish the student's reputation (and, to an extent, the reputation of our program) in the academic community. It should be noted that many journals have their own policies on AI acknowledgement.
3) For research done with coauthors, each of them should solicit an explicit permission from the rest on AI usage and agree on how exactly AI is used.
4) If a student learns about a work not available online (such as a manuscript distributed by its author; a talk w/o notes/slides/video posted; an informal discussion) and wishes to use this work in their research with LLM assistance, the student should request an explicit permission from the author. This is important for maintaining the free exchange of ideas.